

How to actually use Claude

Keep this page: how to ask, what to keep out, and where things are.

1 Ask well: three habits

- Give context:** who it is for, and why.
"I work in the admin office of a research institute. This is for our director, who has two minutes."
- Say what you want back:** format, length, language.
"Give me 5 bullet points and the 3 numbers that matter most, under 150 words."
- Ask for changes.** It is a conversation, so keep going.
"Put the 3 numbers in a table, and make it more formal."

Write in Arabic and Claude replies in Arabic (the menus are not in Arabic).

2 Never put these into Claude

- Passwords and other secret codes
- National ID, Iqama or passport numbers
- Health information
- Student records and grades
- Personal data about other people
- Contracts, tenders, and anything marked confidential or internal
- Unpublished research, patent material, and data covered by a non-disclosure or data-use agreement

3 Your privacy settings

- The switch** (Free, Pro, Max): your initials (bottom left) > **Settings** > **Privacy** > "Help improve our AI models". On: Anthropic (the company that makes Claude) can use your chats to improve Claude and keep them up to 5 years. Off: they are not used, and a chat you delete is gone within 30 days.
- Rating a reply** (thumbs up or down) sends the whole chat to Anthropic, which can use it even with the switch off. Don't rate chats with anything sensitive.
- Incognito** (ghost icon, top right) keeps a chat out of your history and memory, but Anthropic still keeps it for 30 days. Not a safe place for secrets.
- Deleting a chat** does not delete what Claude remembered from it (its memory). Remove that in **Settings** > **Memory**.
- Work plans** (Team, Enterprise): chats are not used to improve Claude, and an admin controls the settings. A KAUST email alone doesn't make it a work account.

KAUST: Don't put sensitive information into Claude. Follow KAUST policy on what you can and can't use.

4 Chat, Cowork or Code?

Chat **Free** Questions, drafts, and summaries of files you attach. You copy the answer out yourself.

Cowork **Paid** Hand Claude a job on a folder, like tidying it. On Manually approve, it checks with you first.

Code (Claude Code) **Paid** Claude works on a folder. In Manual mode it shows each change first. No coding needed.

Start in Chat. Move to Cowork or Code when the job touches your files.

Give them one practice folder (like Documents > Claude-Practice), never all of Documents or Desktop. Keep a backup.

5 Where things are

Add a file: + > **Add files or photos**, or drag the file into the chat.

Connectors (plugs to other apps; connect only what you need): **Customize** >

Connectors . **Your role and tone:** **Settings** > **Account** .

Projects: sidebar > **Projects** . A space that keeps the files and instructions for one piece of work (Free: up to 5).

Add a skill: **Customize** > **Skills** > + **Add** > **Upload skill**

The setting skills need: **Settings** > **Capabilities** >

Code execution and file creation (switch on). It lets Claude make real files, no coding needed.

Code tab on a folder: **Code** > **Local** > **Select folder...** > **Open folder...** > pick the folder > **Trust workspace** > the mode button next to send > **Manual** (asks before every change). A new folder starts in Auto. Auto and Bypass skip the questions: leave them alone for now.

When Claude asks "may I do this?" check which file and what change, then pick **Deny** (no), **Always allow** (yes, don't ask again) or **Allow once** (yes, this time). Not sure? Deny, and ask Claude to explain.

6 Skills

work on Free

A skill is a saved set of instructions that teaches Claude a task you repeat, so you don't explain it every time.

- Add one:** **Upload skill** (see 5). Pick the .zip file (a packed file) without opening it, click **Upload**, and it arrives switched on.
- Make one:** + **Add** > **Create with Claude** . Answer its three questions, then click **Save skill** .
- Make it once, it follows you:** your skills also show up in Cowork and Code.

7 Workflows

paid plans

"Workflow" here is a Claude feature, not the everyday word: many Claude helpers work on one big job at once, check each other's work and combine the results.

Worth it: big, repetitive or high-stakes jobs. **Not worth it:** quick questions.

Try one later:

- Use a paid plan and the **Code** tab.
- On Pro, first switch on **Settings** > **Claude Code** > **Local sessions** > **Dynamic workflows** .
- Type `/deep-research` (a ready-made research job), a space and your question. If asked, click **Once** .
- Start small. A run uses up a lot of your usage limit (how much you can use Claude before you have to wait).

8 Check the answer

Claude can sound sure and still be wrong, most often with **numbers, names, references and quotes**.

A real example: Claude named a real paper, but gave the wrong page numbers.

How to check:

- Open the source and find the quote.
- Search the title in the KAUST Library or Google Scholar.
- Check each number against your file.

9 Plans

What you get	Free	Paid
Chat, files, Projects, skills, incognito, artifacts (documents or charts beside the chat), connectors (plugs to other apps)	Yes	Yes
Cowork, Claude Code (the Code tab), workflows	No	Yes

Paid = Pro (\$20 a month, or \$17 a month billed yearly), Max (from \$100 a month), Team or Enterprise. On Team and Enterprise, an admin can switch features off.

10 Getting Claude

- Download the Desktop app from claude.com/download. Sign in with **Continue with Google** or your email (Claude sends you a link).
- KAUST laptop?** You can install it only if you have admin rights (permission to install software). If you don't, we recommend using your personal laptop.
- Can't install at all? Use claude.ai in your browser for the Chat parts.